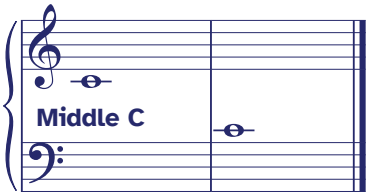
PART I · PITCH · 5

Ledger lines

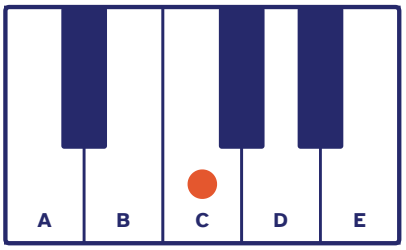
Some notes are too high or too low for the staff. They sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines. Read them the way you read the staff: step out from the nearest staff line, line, space, line.

THE SECRET

Step out from the nearest staff line: line, space, line. The first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

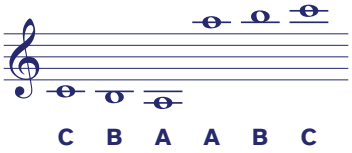


Middle C

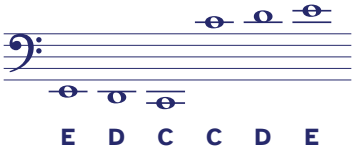


Middle C sits on a ledger line of its own: below the treble staff, or above the bass staff. One key, two ways to write it.

Below and above the staff



Treble: C, B, A below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

Name ledger notes by stepping out from the staff, one letter at a time. Treble: below the bottom line E come D, then Middle C on the first ledger line, then B and A. Above the top line F come G, A on the first ledger line, B, then C on the second. Bass: below the bottom line G come F, E on the first ledger line, D, C; above the top line A come B, then Middle C. The few keys round Middle C, from A below it to E above it, can be written in either staff: the hand that plays them decides.

THE RULE

Count ledger lines from the staff outwards. The first ledger line is the one nearest the staff. Step out line, space, line, and never skip one.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a low note on ledger lines

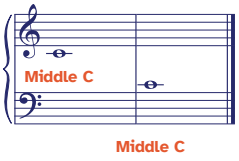


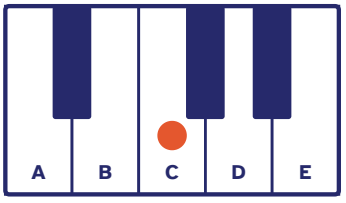
1. **The bottom line** of the bass staff is G.
2. **Step down** one note at a time: F in the space below, E on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: D below it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines below the bass staff: **Low C**, two octaves below Middle C.

EXAMPLE 3

Middle C, two ways

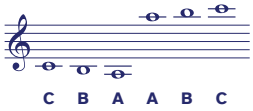




1. **Treble staff:** Middle C hangs on the first ledger line below.
2. **Bass staff:** Middle C sits on the first ledger line above.
3. **Find both on the keyboard.** Are they different keys?

The same key, **Middle C**: the right hand reads it in the treble, the left hand in the bass.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Say the ledger notes.

Treble: C, B, A below; A, B, C above. Point to each one, say it, then play it.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

The four first ledger lines

WHERE	FIRST LEDGER LINE	NOTE
Treble, below the staff	just under line 1	**Middle C**
Bass, above the staff	just over line 5	**Middle C**
Treble, above the staff	just over line 5	**A**
Bass, below the staff	just under line 1	**E**

Two of them are the same key, Middle C. The other two are not: always look at the clef first.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Too many ledger lines? 8va

Very high notes need lots of ledger lines, and lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a high passage is often written lower, with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher** (eight notes up, from a C to the next C, p. 23) until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the notes means an octave lower. (On its own, 8ve is just short for octave.)

GAME

Name the ledger note

1. treble, first ledger line below
2. bass, first ledger line above
3. treble, first ledger line above
4. bass, first ledger line below

Step out from the nearest staff line.

Answer: 1 Middle C · 2 Middle C · 3 A · 4 E.

THINK OF IT Ledger lines are the staff's ladder carried on past its ends: the same rungs, just shorter.

TRAP

- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: step out from the staff.
- × Counting from the outside in: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 32 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Ledger Lines